The 1619 Project: Born on the Water

By Nikole Hannah-Jones and Renee Watson

Questions

My teacher gives us an assignment. “Who are you?” she
asks. “Trace your roots.
Draw a flag that represents your ancestral land.”

Most of my classmates can count back many generations
and learn about the countries where their families
came from.
They draw their flags. But I leave my paper blank.

I do not know where I begin, what my story is.

At home, Grandma asks, “How was school?”
I tell her about the assignment, how I couldn’t finish it.
How I can only count back three generations, here, in this
country --
where my parents, my grandparents, and my great-
grandparents were born.
But before that, I do not know.

I tell her that I am ashamed.

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Grandma gathers the whole family, says,
“Come, let me tell you our beginning.
Let me tell you where we’re from.”

INTRODUCTION

Who are you? For African Americans, the answer is something far more powerful than a simple family tree. Our identity is more than a litany of specific names or places. It is understanding the strength these people said to be “born on the water” needed to survive and how that drive has been passed down through generations.

African American history is not just a story of loss, but a story of resistance (no matter how small) and pride. A story that begins not in shame, but in courage.

Who am I? I am (insert name) and this is . . .

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What Grandma Tells Me

They say our people were born on the water,
but our people had a home, a place, a land
before they were sold.

Their story is our story.
Before they were
enslaved, they were free.

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Their Hand Had a Knowing

Their hands had a knowing.
They knew how to hold a baby close,
how to rock the child to keep her from crying.

Their hands knew how to mix herbs,
how to get the just-right flavor for the meal.

Their hands knew how to beat
and twist and shape iron.
How to make gardening tools, armor, and weapons.

Their hearts had a knowing.
They knew how to make work joyful,
how to create rhythm by pounding the tools against
metal,
knew how to make music to keep them company as
they worked.

Their minds had a knowing,
worldly, curious, sharp.
When they met the white people,
they learned quick, taught their tongues
to speak Portuguese,
taught their eyes to read strange words.

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They knew how to mix the old with the new,
how even an ancient people always had more to learn.

And They Danced

And the people moved their feet,
moved their whole bodies
to the melody of horns and stringed instruments,
of marimbas and drums.

They danced to celebrate, to mourn.
They danced as a way of worship, to offer thanks.

Their bodies a song under open sky and bright sun.
Their bodies a swaying testament to a beauty of
creation.

Stolen

400 years ago, in the year 1619,
. . . the white people took them anyway.
Kidnapped them.
Baptized them in the name of their god.
Stamped them with new names.

Ours is no immigrant story.

They did not get to pack bags stuffed

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with cherished things, with the doll grandmama
had woven from tall grass,
with the baby blanket handed down
from generation to generation all the way back,
so far back that it carried the scent of the ancestors.

They could not hug their fathers and mothers,
daughters and sons,
hearts thumping in rhythm,
clinging to that final sweetness before the parting.
No promises, whispered from mouth to ear,
of seeing each other soon.

Just wails and sobs. Confusion and
wrists worn raw from shackles made of iron,
feet split and bloody from the 200-mile march
along the Kwanza River.

They had no things. But they had their minds.
The old ways, the harvest songs . . .
etched in their memories.

They had their bodies. Histories and bloodlines
and drums pulsing in their veins.
With trembling fingers

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they braided seeds into their hair, defiantly hiding
tiny pieces of home
to plant one day
in new soils.

No matter what some say,
the people fought.
And the white people took them anyway.

Forced them into the bottom of an evil ship,
to sail to a “New World”
they had no desire to see.

Ours is no immigration story.

The White Lion

Maybe it was the second month, or the third,
when they had not seen their land
or any land
for so many days, they could no longer count.

Some could not bear the pain.
They refused to eat.
They shut their mouths
until their hearts gave out.

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Others tossed themselves
into the teal eternity of the Atlantic Ocean,
swimming one last time
with the ancestors.
Sickness and hunger,
filth and cruelty
took the others. Almost half.

But those who did not die
resolved to live
no matter what.

Packed in the dark misery,
strangers chained together
head to feet, hip to hip,
in the bottom of a ship
called the *White Lion*,

they saw that strangers–
men, women, children, kidnapped too,
from many villages–
these were their people now.
These many people
became one people,

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a new people.

And that is why the people say,
We were born on the water.
We come from the people who refused to die.

How to Make a Home

We are in a strange land, they said.
But we are here and we will make this home.
We have our songs, our recipes, our know-how.
We have our joy. We will love, laugh, sing
and hug our children as tight as you can hold a child.
We will survive because we have each other.

Resist

Life was hard,
and it would get harder
for the generations to come.

White people told the people they were not human.
That the people were things
to be bought and sold and given as gifts
alongside horses and chairs.

When the people were beaten,

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they said the people did not feel pain.
When they sold the people's children,
they said the people didn't love.
These were lies they made up
so they could feel okay
about slavery. It was wrong, always
and forever, to own human beings.
It was wrong, always and forever, to treat
human beings like things.

The people fought back.
For 250 years,
the people resisted every day
in ways big and small.
For 250 years,
the biggest resistance of all
was that the people kept living.

Legacy

The people who were born on the water survived.
They were brokenhearted, beaten, and bruised,
but they became inventors and athletes,
nurses and cooks,

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pilots and architects,
farmers and housekeepers,
singers and artists,
dancers and poets,
mathematicians and scientists.

No one could steal the people's joy.
They wrote songs,
created jazz and hip-hop,
rhythm and blues.

Pride

Grandma looks at me and my brother, tells us,
"This is why we say
Black Lives Matter,
why we celebrate Black Girl Magic,
why we believe we are our ancestors' wildest dreams."

"Never forget we are their hope.
Never forget you come from a people
of great strength," Grandma says.
"Be proud of our story, your story."

The next day, I go to school,
pull out my red crayon, my blue, and my white.

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I draw the stars and I draw the stripes

of the flags of the country that my ancestors built,

that my grandma and grandpa built,

that I will help build, too.

And I am not ashamed.

I know what my story is,

where I am from,

where I begin…

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier
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